

Abigail Adams

Letter to John Adams

March 31-April 5, 1776

The most-remembered political statement by Abigail Adams appeared in this private letter, which remained in manuscript for a century. That manuscript, now at the Massachusetts Historical Society, suggests Adams paused between the first and second paragraphs below; she sharpened her quill and changed the tone of her appeal for legal protections for women. The sources of revolutionary political thought are diverse. Recent research by Elaine Forman Crane reveals that Adams drew some of her language from a work of contemporary fiction by Frances Brooke—a two-volume novel entitled The History of Emily Montague, written in Canada and published in London in 1769.

-- I long to hear that you have declared an independency -- and by the way in the new Code of Laws which I suppose it will be necessary for you to make I desire you would Remember the Ladies, and be more generous and favourable to them than your ancestors. Do not put such unlimited power into the hands of the Husbands. Remember all Men would be tyrants if they could. If perticular care and attention is not paid to the Laidies we are determined to foment a Rebellion, and will not hold ourselves bound by any Laws in which we have no voice, or Representation.

That your Sex are Naturally Tyrannical is a Truth so thoroughly established as to admit of no dispute, but such of you as wish to be happy willingly give up the harsh title of Master for the more tender and endearing one of Friend. Why then, not put it out of the power of the vicious and the Lawless to use us with cruelty and indignity with impunity. Men of Sense in all Ages abhor those customs which treat us only as the vassals of your

Sex. Regard us then as Beings placed by providence under your protection and in imitation of the Supreme Being make use of that power only for our happiness.